



30 Minutes Expert

Speed Secrets

Are you the proverbial snail in your office, always slow on the computer? Do you use the mouse for all commands and functions? You should know better. Studies indicate that productivity decreases when you shift back and forth between the keyboard and the mouse to input data. So learn the shortcuts, familiarise yourself with your keyboard, increase productivity, and show all those guys their right place.

While Windows comes with a lot of default shortcuts which simplify tasks like searching and opening windows applications (see box, 'Windows Shortcuts you need to know') you might want to create some shortcuts of your own. The easiest way to create custom shortcuts is through the Windows Start menu.

Assigning shortcuts in the Windows Start menu



You can assign a shortcut to *all* the programs available on your PC. Do the following:

STEP 1 Go to Programs in the Start menu and right-click the application for which you need a shortcut.

STEP 2 Choose Properties from the context menu that appears. There's a text area in the pop up window where you key in your shortcut. Press the key combination, for example [Ctrl] + [F12], that you would like to use as the shortcut access. You are done.

Test this by pressing the assigned key ([Ctrl] + [F12], as in our example) to launch your application.

If there is any default key combination that Windows uses, it will not allow you to assign that combination for your purpose. Instead, it will suggest alternatives like [Ctrl] + [Alt] + [Your key]. For example, [Ctrl] + [C] works across all applications as a copy function and this key combination cannot be used for customisation. When you press [Ctrl] + [C] it automatically

prompts you to change it to [Ctrl] + [Alt] + [C].

Really using the Windows key

Once you've had a taste of shortcuts, you wouldn't be able to resist trying out newer, better options. Another method that you can use to create custom shortcuts is by using a key mapping software.

If you find that keeping track of your favourite shortcut combinations is a pain with the Windows Start menu then you should try Miniwin. This is a system tray utility that lets you use the [Windows] key (present on most newer keyboards) to access programs. Miniwin also allows you to assign shortcuts to open folders, lock desktop, logoff user, shutdown and much more.

Create a new shortcut key



Assuming you use Notepad often, here's how you can assign a shortcut key for Notepad.

STEP 1 Click on the Miniwin system tray icon and choose the settings option.

STEP 2 Now press the Plus button on the Miniwin tool bar. This brings up a window in which you could assign the shortcut for your program.

STEP 3 Key in a descriptive name for the program item and specify the location of the program executable (in this case notepad.exe) and then pick a shortcut key (say n). This will set [Win] + [n] as the shortcut combination that launches Notepad.

Note: While you can use any [Win] key shortcut combination there are very limited options for using the [Alt] or [Ctrl] keys.

Setting the focus



You've done everything but the shortcut still isn't working. What's wrong? Well, it's all about focus! When the focus is not on the software you can't use any of the shortcuts that you have created.

Windows Shortcuts you Need to Know

Have you ever played around with the [Win] key on your keyboard? That's the small key between the [Alt] and [Ctrl] keys. If you haven't, you have lost out on valuable time doing things in a roundabout fashion. If someone comes suddenly behind you and you have some unwanted windows open, minimise all windows in one stroke by pressing [Win] + [M]. You wouldn't get caught this way. There are lots of other [Win] key shortcuts which you could make use of to increase your productivity level and to avoid uncomfortable situations.

Some useful default Windows key Shortcuts

- [Win] + [m] - Minimises all windows
- [Win] + [Shift] + [m] - Undo minimise all windows
- [Win] + [e] - Opens Windows Explorer
- [Win] + [d] - Switches between minimising all open programs and showing them all
- [Win] + [f] - Opens the Find window
- [Win] + [r] - Opens the Run window
- [Win] + [Break/Pause] - Opens System Properties
- [Win] + [Tab] - Cycles through items on the task bar

STEP 1 Click on Miniwin in your taskbar and from the pop up menu choose 'Set focus' (a wiser option would be to assign a shortcut to set the focus too—Miniwin allows you to do the same).

STEP 2 Now when the focus is set, press the appropriate shortcut (in our example it's [Win] + [n]) to start Notepad. ■

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